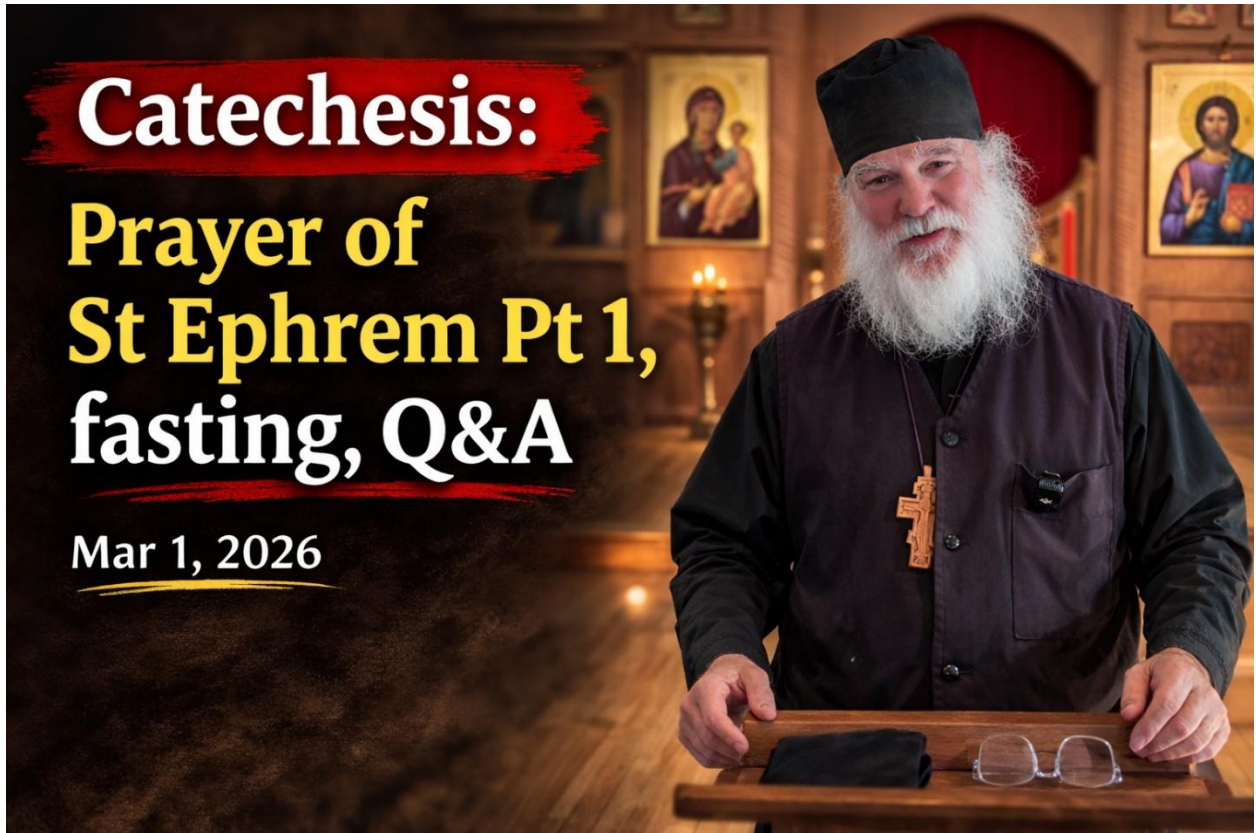


Catechesis: Prayer of St Ephrem, Pt 1, Fasting, Q&A March 1, 2026



Unedited Transcript, from the video: https://youtu.be/OGtwbwb_I4M?si=ABzw-7Kf8VJx2ki

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There may be errors, but this is basically what was said. If there is anything really weird, let me know. Priest Seraphim Holland seraphim@orthodox.net.

In the Name of the Father, and of the Son, and of the Holy Spirit. Amen.

The first thing I'm going to do is answer a question that I was sent, because I wanted to do it by video, but I didn't have the strength to do it last night. So, it's a typical question, and it's a good question to answer: Why do we go fast?

My first answer to why we fast might not be that satisfying to you, but it's really the best answer, and that is: because of obedience. Because the Church fasts. They tell us to fast, and so we fast.

Now, I understand that's not really adequate, especially for someone coming into the Church. But really, obedience is the secret sauce. Obedience to your wife, obedience to your husband, obedience to your children, obedience to your boss, obedience to those who are direct reports to you, obedience to the loudmouth that you deal with.

Obedience is the secret sauce to peace in life. Now, that doesn't mean you do everything everybody tells you, because they could be telling you to do things that are dangerous or stupid or something. But in general, when possible, do what you're told, even if you don't like it. It's very, very useful to be obedient. So, obedience is the secret sauce.

So really, once you're Orthodox for a long time, to me that's the completely full answer for why we fast. But of course, there are things about fasting that are very useful, so we'll talk about those things.

If you're obedient to fasting, then what you're doing is this: food is necessary for life, but it is secondary to eternal life. It's not as important as eternal things. So, you're putting food in perspective. You're not, as they say, living to eat, you're eating to live.

So, when you are ascetical about food, that's something you must have, but you can limit it. You can limit the number of times you eat. You can limit the quality of the food, the quantity of the food. And when you do these things, then we just know by experience that we get stronger in our hearts. Our hearts open to God.

It's not like God says, "You must fast or else I won't do this," or "You must fast or else it's a sin," or any of that kind of garbage. There's no compulsion in the Church. But when you fast, you're just more alert. Everybody knows that if you eat a whole lot of food, you're not very alert, right? I mean, what do people do after a big Thanksgiving dinner? They don't do much. Because you've had so much food, you have to digest it.

Eating a lot of rich food, especially certain types of food, meat at the top of that list—just weighs down the soul. We really shouldn't eat a lot of meat. Our Western diet is horrendous for spiritual life. Whether you're a monk or not doesn't matter. If you're a layman and you eat incredible quantities of meat, it's just not good for you spiritually. We know it's a passionate food. We know that by experience. People might say, "How do you know this?" By experience. The Church knows this.

Remember in Exodus when they're asking for meat— "Give us meat, give us meat." "Here's your meat." That story, you know, the Israelites in the desert—oh yeah, that's right. They wanted it, and what happened? They immediately started getting bitten by snakes.

So, we fast primarily because of obedience. But what happens with fasting is the ascetic life makes you stronger in general. I mean, if you're studying to be a doctor and you don't want to study, and you

want to go out and party, and you want to watch TV, etc., then you'll probably flunk out of med school unless you're really, really brilliant. You have to be ascetical to get through med school or law school or really almost any school.

Maybe not anymore. Now some of the DEI schools, you just have to show up and look weird, and you can get in and act weird and then you're done, right? But you know—like UTD—they just have a lot of weird people at UTD. So, you know... accusations.

So, fasting makes you stronger and makes you more alert. It's really, really helpful to increase your vision, increase your watchfulness. We know this by experience. But the trump card is obedience. We fast because of obedience.

I'm sure there are other things I used to say about fasting, but that's about all I say about it anymore. Anybody have any thoughts about fasting? How'd you do this first week?

"I did pretty good except yesterday I got really sad and my family had a get-together, and I ate something I wasn't supposed to. But when you said something about meat—like I'm really into nutrition. I've heard meat—like an animal-based diet—was really good for you."

Animal-based diets could be good for you, I suppose, but not the stuff you buy in the supermarket. The stuff in the supermarket is terrible because of the way it's raised. But I mean, you can live well on an animal-based diet, a carnivore diet or whatever. But you can also eat well on a Mediterranean diet or just eating intelligently. I would say: if you don't eat anything that comes out of a bag or a box, you're probably going to do pretty well. That's a good start.

"I noticed sleep became an issue early on—amount of time, I just felt exhausted, like I hadn't slept all night. It seemed like the only thing that helped was more fruit."

Well, you know—early on it's very... usually I eat a lot more meat, probably the worst example in terms of avoiding it. But it seems like stopping meat completely puts your body in shock almost.

Well, I think we can do a lot more than we think we can do, to be honest. We should try to do what we're able to do, and maybe a little bit more. Not a lot more, but a little bit more. And with the grace of God, you can do many, many things. But don't aim for bread and water for all of Great Lent. That would be dumb, because we're not spiritually ready for that.

"Yes, Father. I find that people are extremely—like for example, if I'm like, 'No thank you, I'm not eating meat,' they're like, 'Are you not hungry?' And people are scandalized, and they push and try to make you do things. Having to consistently reject them is bizarre to me."

Yeah, but if you said you were fasting to connect with your spirit animal, they'd be great with it.

You know, I don't worry about what people think. I actually don't really have that happen to me. Of course, now I look like this and stuff, but when I was a layman, I went to company stuff all the time. We'd have company dinners and I just didn't eat the meat. I just cut it up and ate the other stuff. Nobody noticed. Maybe you have people that notice more, but... I don't care. If people don't like that I'm not eating meat, I don't care. I'm not telling people. Just go with it. Don't be afraid of peer pressure.

But also, we shouldn't be proud saying, "Oh, I'm not eating meat, but they're eating meat—oh, they're such savages." No. The reason we're fasting is to humble ourselves. Part of being tired is partially humbling ourselves. It's like: I think I'm all that, and I'm tired because I didn't eat a little meat. Golly, what a snowflake I am. So, you start to recognize: where's your strength coming from? It's coming from God. It's not coming from meat or anything else.

So fasting puts things in perspective—very much in perspective. It's beautiful how you see that God is more important than anything else. You're making a value judgment.

People will say—and I correct them, and people who know me well know this—like if it's a Wednesday and they say, "Oh, I know you can't have ice cream today." And I say, "Yes, I can. I choose not to." You can have ice cream on a Wednesday. You can have meat on a Wednesday. But you can choose not to. You're free to choose.

And the freedom of choosing is really empowering. Sometimes you go hungry. I've been on an airplane and had nothing to eat. Okay. Big deal. I'm not going to melt away. It would take a lot of meatless days for me to melt away.

I understand different people have different capacities. So all I want you to do is try to keep the fast the way the Church says. If you're not good at it, that teaches you a little something. I don't want you to literally say, "I'm terrible because I have to have cheese." But it should humble you. It shouldn't crush you. Crushing you is because of ego: "Oh, I should be that guy and I'm not that guy." That's ego.

Just try to fast. If you're able to fast, glory be to God. Your fasting should be with increased prayer. If you're fasting but not praying more, or not trying to read more, be more spiritually attuned, then that's where your fasting could make you proud, or you could end up giving it up.

Any other comments about fasting? Okay. So hopefully that'll be an adequate answer. Number one: obedience. And really number two: it works. The Church knows that it works.

The Lord expected us to fast, right? He spoke about when the Bridegroom's gone, then they will fast. And when you fast, anoint your head with oil and don't look like you're all messed up. He didn't say it exactly that way, but you know what I'm talking about. That's a paraphrase. The Lord expected us to fast. The Church has always fasted.

By the way, here's a rule of thumb that served me very well. When I was a Protestant—and even preaching on beaches and stuff—and all this cacophony of beliefs, and everybody said, "We believe in Jesus, but all this other stuff is negotiable." It's okay. Maybe it's a little weird that you believe in the Eucharist being the Body and Blood of Christ, but it's okay, you're still a brother in Christ, etc., etc.

So all these different beliefs that were mutually exclusive—either you believe it's the Body and Blood of Christ or you just don't. I mean, it's not really an in-between. Unless you're an Anglican—it can be in-between—but they're a special case. I'm going to get some angry comments from Anglicans because of that.

But the thing is, what I decided was: I'm looking for truth. And Jesus said, "I'll send you the Holy Spirit, the Comforter, who will lead you into all truth." So where's the all truth? "All truth" means there's not falsehood, right? It doesn't mean that all the people in this room have a little bit of truth, and if you add those pieces together, that's all truth. That's not what all truth is. All truth is that we believe all the truth and none of the falsehood.

So I figured: if the Church can be found, that's how I evaluate if something should be done or if something's true. By the grace of God, I found the Orthodox Faith—really by historical research and by prayer. And if that's true—if the Church is true—then we must fast. We must pray for the dead. Theotokos is Ever-Virgin. We have a priesthood. We have an episcopacy. We have the Holy Eucharist. We should say the Creed and it's binding on us. And a hundred other things, because all that's within the Church.

So why do we fast? Because the Church does it. That's it. It's as simple as that for me, and I hope it will be as simple as that for you.

I knew somebody—kind of a horror story. He was brought into Orthodoxy, but he never really committed to it intellectually. He started to have doubts, and he asked questions of Father Nicholas and me and somebody else a lot, and every time we started to answer him in a way he didn't like, he would change the subject to another question. Eventually he apostasized and became basically a niche pastor—niche Protestant pastor. Even Protestants think he's a little weird. It's something "free grace" something or other. That's all he cares about: free grace, free grace, free grace. And his doctrine of free grace is so limiting—ask Jesus into your heart, that's it, we don't talk about anything else.

He was evaluating things in the Church based upon whether it was what he believed. It was true if it was what he believed. He even had the audacity to tell me that Gregory Palamas and St. John Chrysostom—there were a lot of mistakes in their sermons. Why? Because he didn't agree with what they said.

He's a Protestant pastor to this day spreading that kind of heresy because his evaluation of the Church was what he believed. I'm telling you: you're not accurate about what you believe. You've got to find out what the Church believes, and then you'll know that you believe correctly. It's very, very important.

All right. I want to talk to you about the Prayer of St. Ephrem. There's a book over there. There's only a few more of them—looks like about six. I can make more. It is an abbreviated prayer book for Great Lent. I want you to basically do this rule. You can do more than it. You could modify it a little bit. But if you're having trouble having a prayer rule, I think this is very good. So I'll go through this rule with you, because I think it's a good starting point.

It's very similar to things I've said before. Basically it's the morning prayers—where you're going to say, "O Heavenly King, Comforter, Spirit of Truth," all the way through the Our Father. Then you're going to do the Troparia to the Holy Trinity—it's all in the Jordanville prayer book. And then "Lord, have mercy" twelve times, the prayer of St. Basil, "Come let us worship God our King," Psalm 50, and the Creed. This is what I've told you to do forever.

And then after you've done that, if you want to do more of the morning prayers, fine. That's great. But I want to make sure you do intercessions. It's very, very important. This is something when I was a Protestant, it just wasn't emphasized at all. We just had quiet times with our Bible. And the idea of having a list of very many people to pray for—including the dead—what an idea. Of course we weren't going to do that. And praying to the saints—none of that stuff was going to happen.

So what I want you to do is make a list. I really want you to make a list on paper or on your computer or on your phone, but it would be better if you have it on paper eventually. And I want you to say for your group of people: "Lord Jesus Christ, have mercy upon my mother." "Lord Jesus Christ, have mercy upon my father," etc., etc. "Lord Jesus Christ, have mercy upon Father Seraphim," and maybe a person that has been difficult for you, whether they're alive or dead—it doesn't matter.

And for some, I would say do prostrations—for the ones that are really close to you, or the ones that have hurt you. When you think about them and your heart is cold—when you have that weird feeling in your heart because of a person—that's a person you must pray for. I don't care if they're alive or dead, Orthodox or not. I don't care if they're a Satan worshiper or anything else. You should pray for them if you have something wrong in your heart when you think of them.

And your list should be something reasonable—ten people, twenty people, thirty people, but not a hundred people.

"Yes, Father—let's say I have anger in my heart toward a group of people I don't even know. Should I try that?"

Yeah. Absolutely. They've crossed your path in some way. Even if you don't know them, maybe they represent a certain philosophy that is abhorrent to you, or have done something that's harmed you or your family and you don't know who they are. Yeah—you can pray for them.

I pray for a guy... You know, I had these shorts that came out of a longer video and they're shorts about the Epstein files, right? And I'm saying: don't look at the Epstein files. I continue to say: don't look at the Epstein files. It's really a dumb idea unless you are a person who must look at them because of your duties. And your duties are not "post it on social media and be mad about it." That doesn't count. What counts is if you're law enforcement, or a judge, or something like that. Then you'd be looking at the unredacted stuff and it would give you nightmares. It would be hard and it would be in your head when you're trying to pray. So I don't want you to do that.

But anyway, there are people who say, "We have to look at these Epstein files," because they believe in magical thinking. Somehow, if we all look at these and we're all disgusted, it's going to change the world. No, it's not. What it's going to do is make your brain, your heart, full of this stuff, and it's going to be really bad when you pray.

Two negatives can happen if you look at the Epstein files. Number one: if you try to pray with intensity, you'll have trouble praying with intensity. You'll have these ideas come to you—not enticing, but disgusting. You don't want disgusting thoughts when you're starting to pray. You have to push them out. That's one bad thing.

The other bad thing is you don't have any trouble. If you don't have any trouble, then you don't really pray, right? If a person doesn't pray intensely, they just rattle off prayers and they don't have any trouble and they say, "It's not a big deal." Yeah—it's not a big deal because you don't know how to pray. You don't pray intensely. You don't pray with your heart.

So if you're trying to pray with your heart, and if you're trying to become an Orthodox Christian, that better be your goal—to pray with the heart—then it's a bad idea.

So anyway, this guy called me up on the phone. I answered. He starts to tell me his view. I agreed on some level with what he was saying but not everything. I said, "Would you like my opinion?" He said okay. I gave my opinion, and he didn't want my opinion. So then he gets angry, curses at me, and hangs up. We had some text exchanges and he was vile and profane and everything.

So I asked him for his name. He wouldn't give me his name, because I said, "I'll pray for you for the rest of my life," and he just had more invective. So I pray for this guy—the guy who was mad at me about the Epstein files. I'm not mad at him. It's just shocking how incredibly angry and passionate people can be about such things.

"You pray for that other guy who started his own church talking to you as well."

I do pray for him, but I pray for him by name, because I know him—and his wife.

"Even earlier this week I had an issue—not even with you personally—it was an author from this book, and it really bothered me. Normally this stuff doesn't bother me, but it did. I tried to take his name and pray for him, prostrations and things like that, and it wasn't as bad but it still clung to me."

Oh yeah. Sometimes it just takes time. You can't unring the bell. It keeps going dong in your head and that's very, very difficult.

Now there are some techniques I recommend all of you—look at Bishop Emilianos's series about Nepsis. There are like thirty-five of them. He's going to be coming back here and I hope to get him to talk more about it.

There are techniques you can use to help when you have this kind of thought in your head that won't go away no matter how much you try. There are things—prostrations, the Jesus Prayer, sometimes even distraction—thinking about something else, like building a rocket ship, or when you had so much fun last year on vacation—an unspiritual thing—and then you make the thought less powerful, and then you can fight it with prayer. Eventually you fight the thought with prayer.

But we have to be really careful about the stuff we put in our heads. Just today I'm observing liturgy and an image from a movie I probably saw fifteen or twenty years ago came to me. And it's like: I don't want to have anything in my head while I'm praying. I don't want that.

It doesn't have to be an image that's really profane or pornographic. It can just be that it's there. I don't want it there. If you're trying to concentrate on somebody talking, you don't even know what they're saying, but you just want them to be quiet. So guard your heart. Guard the things you take in. Be careful.

I would love to go back to my younger self and say, “Do you really need to buy that Led Zeppelin album?” No, you don’t. I can’t imagine how great my life would be if I didn’t have any of that music in my head that I’ve listened to. It’d be great.

And I haven’t heard that stuff for a long time. But still, if I hear it in an auto store or something, I know exactly the lyrics. They’re all there. I don’t know Psalm 2 by heart, but I know the lyrics of Led Zeppelin’s songs by heart, because the devil wants you to remember all that stuff.

So I’m not telling you, “Don’t listen to any rock and roll,” but guard your heart. And the more you start to pray and have some sweetness, you don’t want to get rid of it. You don’t want anything in the way. Whether it’s a good thought or a bad thought, whether it’s good music or bad music—whatever it is—you just don’t want it, because you want to be able to pray with attention and have sweetness.

So this is—you’re just in a battle, Zach. We’re all in a battle. There are techniques Bishop Emilianos talks about that I think would be better for him to say in person. But basically, we have to guard ourselves as much as we can from things that are extraneous.

I think if you encounter things that are difficult because of your duties, that’s one thing. But if you do it because of idle curiosity—does that sound familiar? That’s in the prayer, right?—then it’s really going to harm you.

I was a nurse. I worked with total care of people. I bathed people, saw people naked all the time. I have no problem with any of those images. I don’t remember them at all, because I was doing what I had to do, and it was necessary for me to give good care to people. I don’t have any problem with it.

But some image from a movie I might remember—because that was because of idle curiosity. So be careful. Be very careful. Guard yourself. If somebody accuses you of being prudish—tough. Guard yourself a little bit. It will really help you.

Any other comments or questions?

“So while praying—when you say we need to pray with our whole heart—for me a struggle is that I can’t really control the fact that I have ADHD, but my mind’s going a million different places whenever I’m praying.”

Yeah. Your mind’s going a million places. It’s very hard to do something in the beginning. It’s like riding a bicycle. Very few people ride a bicycle without training wheels or without their dad holding on to it. You have to learn to do it. Same thing with this.

This is why saying the morning prayers, the evening prayers, reading the Psalter—it’s very helpful for beginners and for advanced people, but especially for beginners, because it gives something for you to focus on.

I’ll tell you something that happened to me today—actually it happened last night. Vigil gets long sometimes. You may not be attentive for a little while and all of a sudden I had an image or idea in my head. I didn’t want it. It was tenacious.

So what I did is—kind of—in my mind, it was like I elevated my head, and there were the words being said, bouncing off the walls and everything. For me it was like they were up here, and I was listening very carefully to every word that was being said. Whatever was being read, I was literally listening and processing every word—and the thought went away.

See? That was very helpful.

Another thing I've learned from Bishop Neophytos of Cyprus: he has a beautiful book I recommend to everybody from Orthodox Ethos. In that book he talks about if you have thoughts that are difficult, you can say, "Holy Spirit, cleanse my thoughts." He talked about a pernicious thought that came to him, and he literally just said, "Holy Spirit, cleanse my thoughts." He did it, I think, seven times, and the thought went away.

So that's one thing you can do. If you're in church, you can listen very carefully to the words. Sometimes you can get your prayer rope out and pray very intently: "Lord Jesus Christ, have mercy on me. Lord Jesus Christ, have mercy on me." Really focusing on the words—not on images, not on the face of Jesus—none of that. Just on the words. A lot of times the thought will go away. But sometimes it won't. Some days it won't. We're beginners. We just have to deal with it.

"What if these thoughts come into your dreams?"

Dreams—we don't pay attention to dreams as diagnostic. They're not predicting anything. The only thing a dream might tell you is you have anxiety, right? Like you have test anxiety and you dream you're taking a test and all of a sudden you're naked in the test. That's anxiety. Duh.

Other than that, you just should not pay attention to dreams, and you cannot fully control what's in your dreams. You just can't.

Now we have a custom in our Church about dreams that are sexual in nature, in which you might wake up having had pleasure. Many of you are very young. This happens. We have a prayer rule called "Prayers for Purity." You say this prayer rule and you move along. You don't give it too much more thought. You say: I obviously have some latent impure sexuality in me, but I can't control it when I'm asleep.

Only the very, very perfect can control things when they're asleep. So you just be humble and say, "I'll say the prayers for purity." If you want to find them, I can get them for you. I don't think we have any more at the church right now. I think there are some at the hall and that's it.

You react to the sin. It shows impurity, but it's not a conscious sin. We have the idea of unconscious sin. In the West, they don't really talk about that. We have sins that are voluntary, involuntary, known, and unknown. You could be sinning because you're putting on airs and you don't know you're doing it. Or you might have harmed somebody with your words and you don't know you did it.

So we think there are a lot of things that can be sins. We don't get all crazy about it, obsessive. We just say, "God, forgive me all of my sins." I don't want you to have a conniption fit about it. You're going to have dreams. Some dreams will be disturbing. The devil will try to get you with some dreams,

especially sexual dreams, because he's going to try to get you to do one of two things, and both of them are a win.

The first: the dream was pleasurable and it makes you think you want more of that, and it might incite lust in you, and then you might sin in some other way.

The other: it's so disgusting to you, but you own it. You say, "I must be that guy." You had some terrible dream where you committed fornication or did something weird. "I must be that person." No you're not. It was a dream. It's not you. It describes a dream you had. The devil is trying to make you either desire it or loathe it. Either one works for him.

Instead, what you should do is say, "Oh, I'm glad that's over now," and be happy. Say the prayers and move on with your day. Do you understand? It's really important.

There's sin we commit voluntarily, involuntarily—when we dream, when we're awake. But we deal with sin and then we move along. We don't get fixed in it.

"In the Jordanville prayer book, in the evening prayers, it says, 'Lord Jesus Christ, protect me from dark pleasures and dreams,' and then you go on to have dark pleasures and dark dreams or even nightmares. Then in the morning you say, 'Thank You God for protecting me from dark pleasures and dreams and nightmares.' What's your take on that?"

My take is that God knows you very well, and He will answer you with the best answer. If you trust God, then okay—I still had a dream. Maybe the dream would have been worse. I don't know. I'm not trying to play a mind game with it. But sometimes people think of it in a worldly way: "I prayed for this, it didn't happen, God's not listening." No. Sometimes God says no. Sometimes God says something else. It could have been a way worse dream. It could have been more of them. No matter what, God is protecting you. So we just ask for protection.

People get cancer. People have accidents. Can we say every single one of those people hasn't prayed for God's protection? Of course not—some have. But what is the real protection you really need? The real protection you need is that your soul is united with God no matter what.

"Yeah, it reminds me of Paul—thorn in the flesh."

Yeah, he prayed three times.

"It reminds me of Job."

If you're experiencing God, if you're struggling, if you have some experience of God, then when bad things happen, you don't attribute it to something. You just say: it's part of God's providence. You don't worry about it.

I had somebody tell me recently—oh, I have a story. Father Niles, who's up there in Decatur, they were cutting some tree limbs and clearing around a tree. He said to the person clearing, "Have you asked your guardian angel for protection yet?" They said no. He said, "You need to do that. There are tree limbs up there that could fall on you. We need to ask our guardian angel for protection."

So they said, “Yes, holy guardian angel, protect me.” A tree limb fell on Father Niles—a big one—and he’s tiny. Didn’t hurt him at all.

Right after that—“holy guardian angel, protect me”—a big old limb hits him, bounces off, and he’s like, “See, I told you.” That’s a true story.

“Many saints have said there could be a novice who prays for a passion to be taken, and then when they learn what that passion was doing for them, they say, ‘Give it back,’ because they lost that victory, that crown.”

Yeah. Be careful what you ask for. Be careful what you wish for. We should only wish that God is in our heart. That’s it.

A woman responds: my background is Southern Baptist and then thirty years in Roman Catholicism. Roman Catholicism says we do not presume, but we do not despair. Most of us are more prone to despair than presumption. God doesn’t want us to despair. What’s important is perseverance.

Because I’ve been inquiring about Orthodoxy for three years, and all the prayers of the Church are so beautiful. They’re meant to help—of course, in a more real way than I ever experienced in any other area.

We’re not in the Church yet, but the sacraments have actual supernatural help. When we’re baptized, we’re going to actually be supernaturally helped. When we get chrismation and when we receive—glory be to God—we’re going to be supernaturally helped.

So perseverance is important. The prayers won’t always help us immediately, but perseverance in the prayers will. What do we really think about the strength of God and the strength of the Holy Spirit? He will eventually—you will find in a miraculous way that the prayer will have done its good for you, and you will wake up in the morning and you will not have had any of this. And even if you do, you just move along.

Well, I agree with you. She mentioned perseverance—that’s in the prayer: patient endurance. Let me finish the prayer book a little bit and then we’ll go to the Prayer of St. Ephrem with the time we have remaining.

I really want you to do intercessions. It’s very important. They shouldn’t be arduous. They shouldn’t be like our commemoration list of people—it takes more than thirty minutes now for the people who’ve donated to us. It’s getting longer and longer. But no, you don’t want a prayer list of literally seven hundred people. But you know, ten, twenty, fifty—something like that.

And you should do prostrations for some and say, “Lord Jesus Christ, have mercy upon so-and-so.” If it’s hard because you have family groups, you can say, “Lord Jesus Christ, have mercy upon this group of people.” You don’t have to say each one individually. Do it in a way that feels right.

But make sure you do your intercessions.

I'm suggesting you read the Lenten lectionary. If you don't want to, read the Gospels. I want you to read the Gospels. I'm telling you, you've got to read the Gospels four times to get baptized, right? And you've got to read the Psalter too. But the Lenten lectionary is so delicious. Definitely read it during Great Lent. I've got it online. This book tells you where to get it.

If you have the time, read it. If not, read the Gospels.

Then the Prayer of St. Ephrem. And there are a few other things. The evening prayers are basically the same thing. There are also other things in the back of this prayer book that are amazing—things taken from the Great Canon. I'm not saying you add them every day, but they're great. I try to add all of them when I can, because they're so beautiful.

What I'm asking you to do is something that should take you maybe twenty minutes. Including reading the Psalter, maybe thirty minutes. If you can do twenty, do twenty. If you can't do twenty, do ten. But do something.

A man says he's been trying to read his kathisma. Before, when he first started reading the Psalter, he would do "Glory be..." and stop there. But now he's in this period of reading the kathisma, and it's been very good.

I'm glad. It's an acquired taste, though, because its language is different. It's different than regular language. You have to get accustomed to the peculiar ways it says things. Same with the Gospel. I don't think the Gospel reads like a novel. It reads differently than any other literature—even differently than the epistles. You have to become accustomed to its way of expressing itself, and you get that from repetition.

Another question: can you take a group of people—say Protestant friends—because the list is long, and just say "Protestant"?

Yeah, you can do that. Some people will take their list and have a list for Monday, Tuesday, Wednesday, Thursday, or have an A and B list that they alternate. There are no rules about this. But it's very important to pray for people—very, very important—to dedicate time to it.

Someone says: I think it was St. Gabriel the Fool who said if you haven't prayed for someone you haven't prayed.

Yeah, that's true. And when you're praying for people, you're giving your blood to them. It's very important.

This won't be easy. Sometimes it will be drudgery. It won't be as interesting as reading the Psalter or reading the Gospel, but stick with it because it's really important.

Okay. Let's talk about the Prayer of St. Ephrem the Syrian. I want you to be doing it when? Twice a day—morning and night. You can even do it Saturday and Sunday if you want. Officially, we don't do it in the church Saturday and Sunday. We'll do it this evening, but by that time we're in Monday, because Vespers marks the demarcation point from one day to the next.

But if you want to do it Saturday and Sunday, go ahead. During Great Lent, I do. Some people pray it every day of their life. So if you want to do that, you can.

But definitely during Great Lent: weekdays for sure—morning and evening.

Here it is:

“O Lord and Master of my life, take from me a spirit of sloth.” Or the way we say it—I like this better for some reason because it’s peculiar—“a spirit of sloth, idle curiosity, love of power, and idle talk: give me not.

“But rather a spirit of whole-mindedness, humble-mindedness, patience, and love: bestow upon me Thy servant.

“Yea, O Lord and King, grant me to see my own sins and judge not my brother, for blessed art Thou unto the ages of ages.”

I’m reading a little bit from something by St. Luke the Surgeon, a commentary on the Prayer of St. Ephrem, and I had it translated, so there might be a few glitches here and there. For instance, the translation of the prayer is a little different than what we’re accustomed to, but we’ll get through it.

Why should we do it? Why? I mean, you just do stuff.

We’re in spiritual war. It’s a season of repentance. It’s so intense. The Prayer of St. Ephrem is much like the Our Father. The Our Father is a verbatim prayer we say, but it’s also a template for how to pray. Many of our prayers are like the Our Father, and the Prayer of St. Ephrem is a verbatim prayer you say, but it also is a template for many of our prayers.

We should pray in a humble way. If you read the prayers of St. Ephrem the Syrian, there’s a Spiritual Psalter that’s out—it’s amazing. It’s incredible. I try to read it as often as I can. He was a saint. He said stuff about himself that I don’t even feel about myself. I think I should feel it, but I don’t, and that’s instructive to me. But he was a saint and said these things about himself.

So if a saint talks about himself as being a sinner, what does that make you and me? It’s very humbling to say this prayer.

What I like about it is there’s a certain resolve when I say this prayer. There’s a certain: I want to do these things, but I don’t have the strength to do them, so I’m asking God to help me with them. I really like it for that reason.

I taught it in co-op last week and I gave them homework. Maybe you guys will do this homework. We’ll see.

The homework is: write your own Prayer of St. Ephrem. You can’t use any of the other stuff—you can’t say “idle talk,” etc. Instead, use your own problems.

“O Lord and Master of my life, a spirit of irritation...” etc., etc. “Give me not, but rather a spirit of watchfulness...” etc., etc. Try to make it an opposite, because at least spiritually these things are

opposites. The sin mentioned, and the solution is the corresponding virtue—at least spiritually, not necessarily one-to-one, but that’s how we interpret it.

So try to write your own Prayer of St. Ephrem. I did. I’ve got it in my phone. I don’t want to bring it out right now because I’d have to stop the thing. But I did the homework too.

Someone asks about the prayer book page number. Yes, but the translation—we’ll get to that.

The gold standard for the Prayer of St. Ephrem would be the Greek. The Greek words are... and in Russian especially for the second thing: “grant unto me a spirit...” O Lord and Master of my life.

A spirit of sloth or idleness... In Greek the next word is really “idle curiosity,” but in the Slavonic it’s come down to be “despondency.” Those are very different.

Although if you have sloth—which is not wanting to do spiritual things, being lazy about struggling for your salvation—not just sitting in front of the TV eating potato chips, that’s laziness—I’m talking about that you don’t have zeal to read, to pray, to confess, to repent. That’s slothfulness.

And slothfulness with idle curiosity will dissipate you, and eventually you can have the sin of despondency. In the world we think of despondency as akin to depression. The word doesn’t really mean that. You can be despondent and depressed—that’s common. But you can also be not depressed at all and despondent, because despondency is not depending on God—really weak faith in God—or depending on yourself. Things are going well and you’re not praying—you’re despondent. You’re abandoning God.

So if you have these sins—sloth, idle curiosity, love of power, idle talk—these will lead you to despondency, lead you to not depending on God. So it’s kind of an interpolation in the Russian prayer book.

But in the actual Greek, the word is... it means inactivity, idleness, and the spiritual meaning is idle curiosity.

What do you think idle curiosity is?

“Looking at stuff you’re not supposed to.”

Yeah. That would be idle curiosity. Also, idle curiosity is somebody does something and it’s juicy—so you gossip about it. Or you want to find out which Hollywood person is divorcing which other Hollywood person. Or in your own life somebody’s doing something and you’re involved, you’re a busybody. Or you’re looking at things you shouldn’t be.

Which one of you should be looking at the Kabbalah? No hands went up. Very good.

The Kabbalah has demonic stuff in it. Don’t look at the Kabbalah. Don’t read the Book of Mormon. Don’t read the New World Translation of the Scriptures—the Jehovah’s Witness translation. Why do that? Why expose yourself to that unless you have a specific reason, like scholarship?

“Wait, I have a Book of Mormon—do I throw it out?”

Yeah, I would actually throw it out. I'd tear it up first. One time Marina and I were on vacation and somebody came to evangelize us and gave us a Joel Osteen Bible. I took it because I burned it in the campfire that night. That's one less Joel Osteen Bible.

I took it. I should have said, "Could you give me a dozen?" They're thinking, "Oh, I evangelized this guy."

It used to be you could travel and the Gideon Bible was in hotels. It's no longer. Many times I used the Gideon Bible when I traveled. In fact, I made it a habit: I always read from the Gideon Bible when I traveled, besides the Bible I had, because it was so great that it was there. But it's not there anymore.

"In Marriott Hotels they have them in some. And sometimes they have a Gideon's Bible and the Book of Mormon."

Oh, they do? Yeah. So you have both.

All right. So let's go through this prayer. We said: why do we do it? Because it's a way of expressing our need to God, and we do it with prostrations.

One of my favorite things is to do prostrations. Let me go through how you do it. There's a short form and a long form. I want you to do the long form. Unless you're really tired—then do the short form. I don't want you not to do it. If you say, "Ugh, I don't want to do it the long way," then do the short way. If you don't want to do prostrations, do bows. If you don't want to do bows, sit down. I don't care. Say the prayers. Don't let these things keep you from praying.

Optimum would be to stand up and do prostrations, but it's better to do a little thing than not do the big thing. That's a very important spiritual principle.

So you'll say: "O Lord and Master of my life, a spirit of sloth, idle curiosity, love of power, and idle talk: give me not." Then you do a prostration all the way to the ground.

Then you stand up: "But rather a spirit of whole-mindedness, humble-mindedness, patient endurance, and love: bestow upon me, Thy servant." Another prostration.

Then: "Yea, O Lord and King, grant me to see my own sins and judge not my brother, for blessed art Thou unto the ages of ages." Prostration.

Then you will do what's called bows: "O God, cleanse me a sinner, have mercy upon me," like this. You can touch the ground if you want. Do that twelve times. It's really good to count that.

Then you'll say the entire prayer all the way through again, and then a prostration. So that's four prostrations and twelve bows. It doesn't take very long. Just take your time doing it.

If that's the only thing you do for your morning prayers, then let it be. At least you've done that. Let it be a goal that you say this prayer in the morning and in the evening.

Any questions before we start to get into the meat of the matter?

"What was the procession about today? And how did everyone know to bring icons?"

We told them. It's just a tradition. This is the Sunday of Orthodoxy. It celebrates the restoration of icons in the eighth century—eighth century, right Father? There was a time of iconoclasm of probably over a hundred years, where people were killed because of icons, put in prison, tortured because of icons—by Orthodox Christians, by emperors and such. And then finally the icons were restored.

There have been little things here and there, especially close to where Islam was, because Islam is very iconoclastic.

I once was getting a catalog from Islam about clothing, and all the models they would just show from here down. They wouldn't show their head, because I think it's forbidden to pictures of the face. But they had all the other stuff. Some of the dresses—it wasn't leaving a lot to imagination, but no head.

Okay, so let's start. "How did parishioners know it would be this Sunday?"

Because it's on the calendar. The first Sunday of Great Lent is the Sunday of Orthodoxy. Our calendar probably says Sunday of Orthodoxy. That's on the front page of orthodox.net. It doesn't say that? So people just know it's every year the first Sunday of Lent. Also, we send a message to the email list. I'll make sure you get on the email list.

Okay. Let's see what he has to say. Let's talk about "O Lord and Master of my life"—a spirit of sloth. For some people that's idleness, but I think sloth is a much better definition. Sloth is one of the seven deadly sins. Sloth is so damaging. It's that spiritual lethargy—you don't want to pray, you don't want to fast, you don't want to read, you don't want to struggle. There's a chance for you to do something good, but you don't do it because it's going to put you out. That's sloth. Sloth is incredibly damaging.

So you have to fight against sloth. All of us to some extent are little sloths with our three fingers hanging in the trees. It's very damaging. I don't really know exactly how to tell you to fight against it except certainly to ask the Lord to help you. That's the beginning.

If you have sloth, pray that you don't have sloth. If you have lustful thoughts, pray that you don't have lustful thoughts. If you have someone you're really bitter about, pray that you not be bitter about them, but also pray for them. Ask God for the things you need. It's right in Scripture. He says you should ask for things that you need.

Does the Lord want you to be without sloth? Is that a good prayer? Does He want you to not have lustful thoughts? Obviously those prayers are pleasing to God. Whether or not you'll immediately be the Energizer Bunny, as soon as you pray, "Please help me not to have sloth"—that's probably not going to happen. But eventually it will.

Sloth is damaging and you have to pray against it. Now you can look active and still be full of sloth. For instance, you can come to vigil but be dreaming about something else.

St. Basil the Fool for Christ in Moscow—by the way, St. Basil's Cathedral by the Kremlin is not for St. Basil the Great. That's for St. Basil the Fool for Christ. He went on the streets, acted like a fool, like he was crazy, people made fun of him, but he had deep spirituality and he was always getting on Tsar Ivan the Terrible.

One time he was in church and Tsar Ivan made some reference to being in church, and St. Basil says, “I didn’t see you there.” Ivan says, “Yes I was. I was right there. You saw me.” St. Basil says, “No you weren’t. You were there, but your mind was somewhere else, building a palace somewhere.” Because he could see Ivan was thinking about something else. That’s sloth. If you’re there to pray, you should be praying.

So you can look active and have sloth. I learned something as a priest. I’ve been a priest now—almost in a couple days—couple days I will come to my thirty-first anniversary.

There’s lots of activity with a priest, like there’s lots of activity for a mother or father. But if you do not spiritualize that activity with prayer, it’s empty activity—even if it’s important things: serving services, going to people’s houses, hospitals, traveling to mission areas, encountering people’s problems, counseling.

I learned the most important thing I should do is pray for the people I’m ministering to. Now, I did pray for them, but I didn’t understand how intense it had to be. And I think there was sloth there. I was working hard, but I wasn’t working in the right way.

They say work smarter, not harder. I wasn’t working smarter as much as I was working harder. My heart was in the right place. I was struggling to do what I thought I should do. But the most important thing is prayer for people. It has to be the first and the middle and the last thing you do when you’re ministering to people.

So you can look active and still be slothful. It’s a sneaky problem.

Now the next thing: in Russian it’s “despondency.” To us it is “idle curiosity,” and we talked about that. We really have to guard ourselves against idle curiosity.

I think this time of human existence is the most beset by idle curiosity of any other time, because we have all these avenues for it. People are not different, but could people literally know everything—every bad thing—about every politician and every movie star two hundred, three hundred years ago? No. Because they didn’t have a phone in their hand. They didn’t have the internet.

Now we have this ability to anesthetize ourselves with this stuff. We have the ability to get so much dopamine in our head that we become a dope. This idle curiosity is very dangerous. We have to guard ourselves against it because it’s so prevalent.

There are companies making this stuff. They have hundreds of people figuring out how to make you addicted to doomscrolling. They’re literally engineering it. So you’re up against a very, very strong adversary.

So if you don’t have intensity in your life, then when you’re a little bored, you pick up your phone, and all those images come in—and they’re going to come out when you don’t want them. Idle curiosity is horrific.

If you want to learn not to be too curious about people, become a priest. I've learned so many things about people—things I would prefer not to know sometimes—but I know those things because of my duties.

In general I've heard a lot of things. Those things I've heard in the course of counsel and helping people might have been heavy to me, but they weren't really something that came to me in my prayer and thoughts so much. But if I had idle curiosity, I would have trouble.

There's some in the Epstein files I have experienced—people who have had problems. I haven't been beset by those problems. But if I read the Epstein files, I definitely would be, because that would be idle curiosity.

"Is this the same as nosiness?"

Yes. Nosiness. Busybodiness. Sometimes translations say nosiness, busybodiness. That's an interpolation, but it's exactly true. We shouldn't be busybodies. We should help people and be there for people, but you shouldn't want to know all the dirt about people.

"What about crime shows?"

I wouldn't do them. I wouldn't do true crime podcasts. I've seen a few, but a long time ago. I wouldn't do it. Anything gross and violent—we shouldn't expose ourselves to it. Those procedural cop shows—they're not solving a problem of somebody stealing the neighbor's cat. They're solving horrible murders. I disagree with it.

Interesting? It is interesting. But I'll tell you what's really interesting: the Gospel is really interesting. The lives of the saints are really interesting. If you want violence, read the lives of the saints—there's plenty of it.

And you can read about terrible things in the news. I just saw something recently—I wish I hadn't seen it. Somebody told me something about what was in the Epstein files and it stuck in my head. I was trying to get rid of it.

That stuff I've heard from the lives of the saints never bothered me when I read them—never—because it was in the context of reading about holy people doing holy things. Maybe unholy things were done to them, but they were righteous and triumphant.

So the thing itself isn't necessarily what marks you. It's the context of the thing. Read the lives of the saints. But I wouldn't read true crime. I wouldn't do it.

"Well, also the saints do actually help us."

Yes, of course. Whereas Epstein needs our prayers.

By the way, I just had a thought—the Ayatollah Khamenei was killed in the bombings, right? And some people were jumping up and down about it. The thing is: a man lost his life and has gone to judgment. That is important. Whether he was a good guy or a bad guy, he is now facing his judgment.

For the next forty days—or now twenty, maybe thirty-eight days—he will be shown heaven and hell, and then go to Hades to await the judgment. I wouldn't wish what might happen to him on anybody. You shouldn't rejoice that a person like him is killed. Maybe it's going to help Iran, maybe not. I don't know. You might have political opinions. But that's a human being now facing God. We should never lose track of that.

Someone mentions the news was his family and grandson were there. I'm not going to comment on whether it should have been done or not. Donald Trump does not have a phone that he picks up and asks my opinion.

So this is tongue-in-cheek, but is it idle curiosity to know that?

To know what—that he was killed? No, because it was reported.

“Well what's the line between following news and it crossing into idle curiosity?”

That's an interesting question. I found out kind of accidentally. I don't read news generally. I find things out sometimes, but I don't generally read main news.

I personally think a person who says, “I'm a political junkie,” I wouldn't do it. I wouldn't do it because it's so much stuff. It's always about “our guys are right, those guys are wrong.” It might be true. But what's that thing they say—when you point a finger at somebody, there are three fingers pointing back at you.

I'm not telling you not to read the news, but be careful. You have a big job. You're trying to train your soul to be still, and you've spent years being anything but still. It's hard to be still. You've got to do the best you can.

So I don't recommend you be a political junkie. If you like politics, go for it, but I wouldn't do it myself. I'm not forbidding it. You have freedom to look at politics. Just guard yourself carefully.

Where you especially should not have idle curiosity is in interactions with others, and all the bad things people do, and all the stuff. You shouldn't be at the so-called water cooler talking about an employee who's a problem. If you're the manager of that employee, then you talk to your manager and deal with it. That's not gossip. But if you're just talking to people at the water cooler, it's gossip. That's idle curiosity, and it's dangerous.

If you want to look at news, go ahead. You want to check hockey highlights, go ahead—I've been known to do that. But I'm not reading hockey news to find out who did terrible things. I just want to see who scored. I just want to see that the Stars won.

“Oh, Penguins.”

You're not like the Stars? I play their junior... You actually play hockey? Oh, cool.

All right. So we covered idle curiosity. Next: love of power. “A love of power: give me not.” What does a person act like if they have love of power?

“Megalomaniac.”

Okay—joke. But what is love of power?

“Prideful. You like the finest seats.”

Okay. I’ll tell you love of power: somebody cuts you off in traffic and you’re mad. How dare they do that to me? Love of power is you call some helpline and you’re talking to somebody who doesn’t speak English hardly, and then it hangs up on you and you’re mad. When you’re inconvenienced: how dare they do that to me?

Love of power is you need to have your way. You need to have your say. You need to manipulate matters to turn out the way you want them to be. Love of power is dissatisfaction because that person got a promotion but they’re no good. That’s love of power.

Love of power is what happens when you don’t have humility. Humility is to give way to people. That’s why I said at the beginning for fasting: obedience is the secret sauce. Obedience is anti-love of power. Obedience is: I’ll do what I’m told. It’s great to do what you’re told instead of, “How dare they tell me to do this.”

That’s love of power. Love of power is why Lucifer fell—his lust for power. He was the most shining of all the angels, over all the angels. It’s a hierarchy. He was in charge. But the purpose of being in charge was to worship and serve God. He wanted to be worshiped. He wanted power. And then he fell.

Terrible thing to have love of power. It’s everywhere. If you feel inconvenienced by something, it’s love of power. If you’re mad because you didn’t get to express your opinion or somebody didn’t agree with you—it’s love of power. If you manipulate situations—it’s love of power. If you complain because you’re not happy about some situation—it’s love of power. It’s everywhere.

All right. Father Nicholas sent me a note. When he sends me notes, that means I’m in trouble. He’s going to get the hook in a minute.

So that was the end of those things. We didn’t talk about the virtues yet. I think I’ll cover the virtues next week, and then I’ll get back to Luke—Sermon on the Plain. I lost my notes for a while because I had a computer die, and now I’ve got them back. So I think I’ll go back to the Sermon on the Plain.

Get this book—there’s only about six of them. Anybody who hasn’t gotten it, go get it. This one’s not in color, but you can use it if you want as well. We’ll start Vespers in a few minutes.

Someone asks: is the PDF anywhere?

Actually it says that it’s online, but I haven’t found my password to log in to FTP because my computer’s down. I’m trying to figure out where I saved the password because it’s a weird password. So right now it’s not online. I say it is. This book is lying to you. It says it’s there, but it’s not really there.

Is the next class next week or two weeks?

Next week. Well, are you going to teach next week? If you ask me, sir.

Well then teach. What do you want to teach about? You tell me.

We'll talk about it. Q&A. Let's do Q&A and State of the Union—how you guys are doing—that sort of thing.

Father Nicholas is going to speak for an hour and a half. And we're going to actually have paid agitators outside, so it'll be like a real State of the Union.

All right. God bless you. We're going to begin Vespers in a minute.

It is truly meet and right to call thee blessed, Theotokos, the ever blessed and all immaculate and the Mother of our God; more honorable than the Cherubim and beyond compare more glorious than the Seraphim; who without corruption gavest birth to God the Word: the very Theotokos, thee do we magnify.

So that was actually an hour and twenty.